

MARBLE MAHARAJAS

Wholesale grain merchants from Ulara village in Rajasthan, the three Patni siblings—Ashok, Suresh and Vimal—spotted the potential of marble mining in the late '80s. A calculated strategy of leasing mines, including the sprawling one at Morwad in 1993, acquisition of two mines in Vietnam along with imported equipment helped the Patnis change not just their own

Visitors and staff at the headquarters of industrial explosives manufacturer Solar Industries in Nagpur, some 820 kilometres away from Mumbai, need to leave their shoes on numbered racks at the office entrance and walk barefoot on the sparkling white marble floor. There is nothing flamboyant about the interiors, except for occasional Hindu iconography. There are fresh flowers, too, in porcelain vases on most working desks, their perfume intermingled with the scent of *agarbattis*. "The workplace is a temple, our customers gods," says Satyanarayan Nuwal, 70, as he welcomes guests into his sprawling office. You may be forgiven for thinking you have entered the office of just another small-time businessman in just another Tier II town.

Until you stumble across the hard facts. Nuwal, sporting a sleeveless khadi waistcoat over a stiffly-ironed blue cotton shirt, a vermilion *tilak* on his forehead above gold-rimmed glasses, is the 120th richest Indian as per the Hurun Rich List 2022, worth a staggering Rs 14,700 crore. His company, the world's fourth largest explosives manufacturer, is also India's largest exporter of commercial explosives used in infrastructure projects and mining, counting clientele in 60 countries. It also makes warheads for the Indian military's Pinaka and Agni missiles. Nuwal, whose circumstances did not allow him to study beyond Class 10, now employs several PhD holders among his diverse 7,500-strong workforce.

For long, India's premier metropolitan cities such as Mumbai, Delhi, Kolkata and Chennai have served as the crucibles of enterprise, giving spirited entrepreneurs from across the country the capital and the clientele crucial to build and broad-base their businesses. The evolution of the information technology and automobile manufacturing sectors